Whose Name Is on It?

Things to notice and note about Mom's accounts, home and family before a Medicaid review.

You know roughly what Mom has. You may be less sure whose name is on the house, whether anyone else is named on her accounts, or what became of the CD she used to mention. This guide names fifteen everyday details worth noticing and, for each, what to write down.

Notice and record. Don't interpret. What any of these means for Medicaid depends on Mom's state and her whole situation, and that is a question for a professional; the notes you keep are what make that conversation useful. The areas below follow what the federal long-term care site and Medicaid.gov say a state looks at or may ask about when someone applies. The wording about what to write down is ours.

Mom's care and where she lives

1 Where she is being cared for

NOTICE The kind of place it is (a nursing home, a rehab unit, assisted living, her own home with help) and the day she arrived or the help began.

WRITE DOWN The name of the place, the date, and who is paying the bill at the moment.

2 Her home state and address [3]

NOTICE Where she lived before she needed care, where her mail goes now, and whether she has moved from one state to another.

WRITE DOWN Her current address, the state, and when she last moved.

3 The help she gets each day [1]

NOTICE What staff or family help her with: bathing, dressing, eating, moving about, medications. And whether the facility or her doctor has done an assessment of her care needs.

WRITE DOWN What she is helped with and by whom, and who assessed her and when, if anyone has.

What comes in, and what goes out for care

4 Regular deposits [1]

NOTICE Each deposit on the bank statement that repeats: Social Security, a pension, veterans benefits, interest, dividends.

WRITE DOWN Where each one comes from, how often, and whether you've seen the letter or statement behind it.

5 The care bill

NOTICE Who each bill is addressed to, which account it's paid from, and whose name is on that account.

WRITE DOWN The date of each bill, who paid it and from which account. If a line on it isn't clear, ask the business office what it is.

Whose name is on it

6 Bank and investment accounts [1]

NOTICE The names printed at the top of each statement: Mom alone, Mom and her spouse, Mom and one of the children, or a trust.

WRITE DOWN The names exactly as printed, and when a name was added, if anyone knows.

7 The house and any other property [2]

NOTICE The names on the deed and on the property tax bill, any mortgage or home equity loan statement, and who lives in the house now. The same for any land, second home or vehicle.

WRITE DOWN The names, where the deed or title is kept, any loans, and who is living there.

8 Trusts [3]

NOTICE The word “trust” or “trustee” on a statement, on a deed or on a folder in the filing cabinet.

WRITE DOWN The name of the trust, who set it up and when, if anyone knows, and where the document is.

9 Life insurance and annuities [4]

NOTICE Policy statements in the mail, premiums going out on the bank statement, or regular payments coming in from an insurance company.

WRITE DOWN The company, the owner named on the policy or contract, and where the paper is. Copy any values as printed.

Family and history

10 A spouse [5] [2]

NOTICE Whether Mom is married, where her spouse lives now, and which accounts and bills are in whose name.

WRITE DOWN The spouse's name and address, the date Mom moved into care, and any statements you can find from around that date.

11 Gifts and things that changed hands [2]

NOTICE Large checks or withdrawals on old statements, help given to children or grandchildren, something sold or signed over to a relative, a name added to or taken off an account or a deed.

WRITE DOWN What happened, roughly when, who was involved and what paperwork exists. Don't decide whether it matters.

12 Accounts that went down or closed [2]

NOTICE A balance much lower than it used to be, or an account someone remembers that no longer shows up.

WRITE DOWN Which account, roughly when it changed, and where the money went, if anyone knows.

Papers and conversations

13 Letters and notices

NOTICE Anything from the Medicaid agency, Medicare, Social Security or an insurance company, and anything the facility hands you about payment.

WRITE DOWN The date on it, who sent it and where you put it. If you can't tell what it's asking for, ask the sender.

14 What you've been told

NOTICE Things said about Medicaid in a hallway, on the phone or at the business office: “too much money,” “spend down,” “you should apply.”

WRITE DOWN The words as closely as you remember them, who said them and when.

15 What you can't find [2]

NOTICE The statements, policies, deeds and letters you expected to turn up and didn't.

WRITE DOWN What is missing, where you've looked, and who might have a copy.

When a note isn't enough

If anyone is thinking of spending, selling, giving away or retitling something of Mom's, or a letter arrives that asks for a reply, that's a conversation, not a note. Anything about a deed, a trust or a transfer goes to an elder law attorney. Questions about how her state's Medicaid rules may apply go to your Medicaid planner. A letter you can't make sense of goes back to whoever sent it, or to the facility's business office.

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't say what any of these means for Medicaid, whether anything here helps or hurts, or where Mom stands, and it isn't legal, financial or tax advice. A professional who knows her state does that, and does it better with your notes in front of them.

Ready for the next step?

You've noticed and noted. The planning interview gives those notes somewhere to go: it asks about each part of your family's situation in turn and gives you a free planning report you can bring to any conversation about paying for care.

Get Your Free Planning Report ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

1. Administration for Community Living (LongTermCare information), Medicaid Eligibility
2. Administration for Community Living (LongTermCare information), Applying for Medicaid
3. Medicaid.gov (Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services), Eligibility Policy
4. Administration for Community Living (LongTermCare information), Glossary
5. Medicaid.gov (Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services), Spousal Impoverishment